# Analysis of the correlation between GDP and the number of summer Olympic medals won

**Business Statistics 1 – Final Project**

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## Executive Summary

The main subject of this project will be the relationship between countries' GDP and the number of medals won at the Olympic Games. In a second phase, we will also look at the dependency and correlation between the two. We will then observe and add another factor, the number of inhabitants per country.

To do this, we chose all types of medals, a total of 204 countries, and focused on the 2020 Summer Olympic Games in Tokyo. We started with our own assumptions, thinking that the GDP would have a strong impact on the number of medals won, and that the more populous a country is, the more likely it is to win Olympic medals, since it might have more potential to have talented athletes. We had three main variables, GDP, the number of medals and the population of each country.

We used various methods to determine the correlations between our three variables, such as histograms, conditional density and scatterplots to support our analysis and obtain scientific results for our assumptions.

We did find a correlation between GDP and the number of Olympic medals won, with some countries being exceptions and helping us to find our limits. For populations and the number of Olympic medals, the correlation is much less visible, if not non-existent. These results have helped us to identify the limitations and problems we faced when collecting the data or analyzing the graphs.

# 1. Introduction

As the founder of the modern Olympic Games, Baron Pierre, once said: "Olympism is not a system, it is a state of mind. It can permeate a wide variety of modes of expression and no single race or era can claim to have the monopoly of it."[1] The Olympic Games reflect the global performances that humans manage to achieve over the years, all nations combined. It's a global culture to urge some to evolve and go beyond the norm with the means available. In any form of competition, defining justice and fairness between players can be complicated, as well as determining the means that are genuinely at their disposal.

To shelve into these questions and concepts, we choose to use the GDP (Gross Domestic Product) to see if there is any correlation with the number of Olympic Medals that a country could win at the Summer Olympic Games. Then we'll explore whatever a larger GDP increases the chances of winning Olympic Medals. The focus will be on some selected games.

Afterward, we want to examine if the country hosting the Olympic Games could have any impact on how many medals they could win and check what kind of external factors could affect the number of Olympic medals that a country could win. If so, we want to explore the reverse correlation, to see if hosting the Olympic Games increases the GDP of the country.
The countries chosen are all those that participated into Olympic Games to gather information about any possible exceptions. We aim to identify If there is any country with a low GDP that has many Olympic medals or conversely, a rich country that doesn't have as many medals as expected and what could be the reasons for such exceptions.

With all those theories and questions, there will be three main axes to our study to make it easier and clearer to follow:

- → The link between the GDP and the number of Olympic medals of a country, spotting the correlations and any exceptions.
- → How low-GDP countries compete with high-GDP countries in terms of Olympic performance.
- → Is there a correlation between the size of a country and the number of medals it wins at the Olympic Games, and does this factor have a stronger relationship than GDP with the number of medals won per country at the Olympic Games.

[1] https://olympics.com/ioc/pierre-de-coubertin

## 2. Data

For this analysis, several series of datasets were required. At first, a database with the GDP of all the countries before focusing on those that participated in the 2020 Olympic Games. This serves as a solid basis for the entire project. The second database was the number of medals won by country in the 2020 Olympic Games in Tokyo. Once we selected our two databases, correlating them gave us a precise answer to our assumptions.

This correlation includes the GDP of every country in the World, regardless of continent. The GDP of every country allows to see if a country having a big GDP could win a medal more easily than a country with a smaller GDP. This database can sometimes lead to relevant information. Per capita GDP has also been used to deepen our reflections and research, specially towards the correlation between the number of medals depending on the size of the country. Some data have been filled manually to have all the GDP necessary to complete our database.

Our second database is the number of medals won by country at the 2020 Olympic Games. It includes all participating countries with the numbers of medals won as a total. They were separated by the type of medals won (Gold, silver, bronze). This dataset enables to compare countries with similar GDPs but different Olympic results.

## 3. Gathering

To use correctly the data, we collected and did the statistics needed to get through it, we used R software. Since our aim was to measure the correlation between the GDP and the medals won, as mentioned earlier, we analyzed and evaluated these two main factors.

## 4. Overview

The variable in our database "Country" shows all the nations participating in the Olympic Games. "Country" is a qualitative character. "Gold Medal"," Silver Medal", and "Bronze Medal" are as their names indicate the different types of medals won. These are quantitative characters. "Total" is a character that shows the sum of medals won by countries (Gold, Silver and Bronze). Rank by "Total" is the World ranking of the Numbers of medals won between countries. "GDP" is the Gross Domestic Product. "Population" is the number of inhabitants. "GDP per capita/pop" represented GDP per capita.
The labels will tell us what each country won at the Olympic Games, their World rankings at the Olympic Games. The labels will also show the country's GDP and GDP per capita.

## 5. Methodology

In our statical project, we will use the R software that will allow us to observe some variables, to relate these variables and to analyze the relationships between these variables.
First, there will be a description of the barplots to observe the anomalies and to observe which trends (increasing, decreasing), they may or may not have, then we will link our barplots.
Afterwards, the goal will be to see whether the variables are independent or not and to see the correlation between the two.
Before concluding, another variable will be added to our analysis, the number of inhabitants of a country.
Finally, we will try to answer to our questions in the introduction to the discussion point.

## 6. Analysis

In our analysis, some countries didn't win any medals. Only 93 countries received at least one Medal out of the 204 countries that participated in the Olympic Games. It won't be worth it to discuss their case in our case, since one of the variables we chose would be non-existent for them. We're going to focus on the 93 countries that have won medals. Moreover, in our analysis some nations are part of a same country (a country can be represented by several nations).

**Descriptive analysis of the 30 countries with the largest GDP and their medals**

Figure 1.1

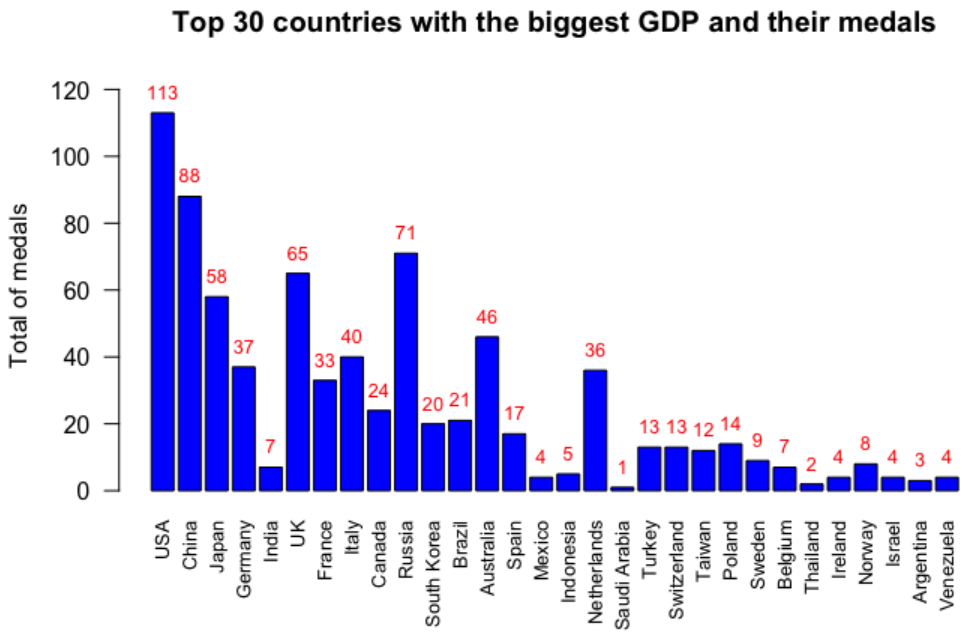
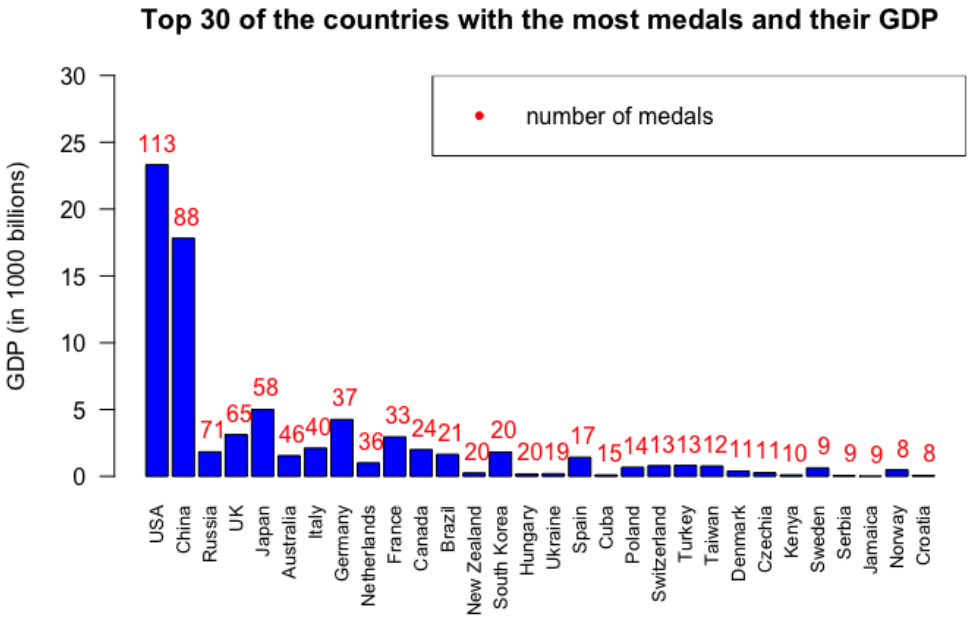



Figure 1.1 shows the medals won at the Tokyo 2020 Olympic Games by the 30 countries with the biggest GDP. In the figure 1.1, Taiwan is an exception because it's a nation and not a country. In any case we have its GDP, it won't be an issue or special case. Each blue bar represents a country that has won at least one medal and is one of the top 30 countries with the highest GDP participating in the Tokyo Olympics. This makes it possible to see if a country with a large GDP was more likely to win at least one medal.

On the figure we can discern exceptions such as India, which has a very large GDP but doesn't have a lot of medals won during the Olympic Games. As you can see, other countries are doing so. Most countries are in a situation where GDP is high but their performance at the Olympics Games doesn't follow. Some cases may be more logical, such as the United States, which has a large GDP but also a very good performance in the Olympics, with more than 100 medals won.

**Descriptive analysis of the top 30 countries at the Olympic Games with their GDP**

Figure 1.2




The Figure 1.2 shows the 30 countries with the most medals won at the 2020 Olympics (in red) and the GDP they achieved in 2020 (blue bar).

We can see that the blue bars aren't going downwards, there are exceptions; some countries have won more medals than others but have a lower GDP, explaining these anomalies. Conversely, countries with fewer medals may have a higher GDP than some countries that have won more medals.
In general, the GDP is decreasing gradually with the most medalists to the least medalists.

**Relationship between Figures 1.1 et 1.2**
In both cases, the United States and China lead the charts in terms of how many medals they won and the highest GDP. In other cases, such as that of India, which despite his very large GDP (figure 1.1) is not shown in figure 1.2, his performances at the Olympic Games aren't enough to compete with the 30 countries with the most medals. This would imply that GDP doesn't play a big role, but to make a causal conclusion simply on a correlation wouldn't be fair. In addition, there are some contradictions, such as Japan and the United Kingdom, which can be found in both figure (1.1 and 1.2). In the case of India, it seems obvious that it's among the 30 biggest GDP of the countries participating in the Olympic Games, it's one of the most populous countries in the world. But as figure 1.2 shows, India is not among the 30 most medalists because only some Indian athletes remain higher than that of less populous country such as Switzerland, which nevertheless ranks among the 30 most medalists.

This relationship is important, it allows a better visualization of the importance of GDP in Olympic performances. As it can be seen, the countries with more than 20 medals (such as the United States, China, France, Italy, ...) are also among the 30 countries with the highest GDP of the participating countries, which shows that their high GDP partly influences their performance. As for the countries that are below 20 or more medals, they're not necessarily in the countries with the biggest GDP. It's noted here that their medals can be won on sports or disciplines dedicated to them. In these anomalies, we can observe, countries such as New

Zeeland, Hungary, Cuba, Kenya, and Jamaica. These countries have won some medals, but they don't have a big GDP, if not a mediocre GDP. Sweden is an example of another kind of anomaly, it has a higher GDP than Serbia, but has won fewer medals than Serbia.

**Table of joined density**

| GDP\ Medals | 0 | 1-9 | ≥10 | Total |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| $< 10^{10}$ | 0.245 | 0.029 | 0.000 | 0.275 |
| $10^{10} - 10^{11}$ | 0.255 | 0.137 | 0.000 | 0.392 |
| $10^{11} - 10^{12}$ | 0.044 | 0.152 | 0.054 | 0.250 |
| $> 10^{12}$ | 0.000 | 0.015 | 0.069 | 0.083 |
| Total | 0.544 | 0.333 | 0.123 | 1 |

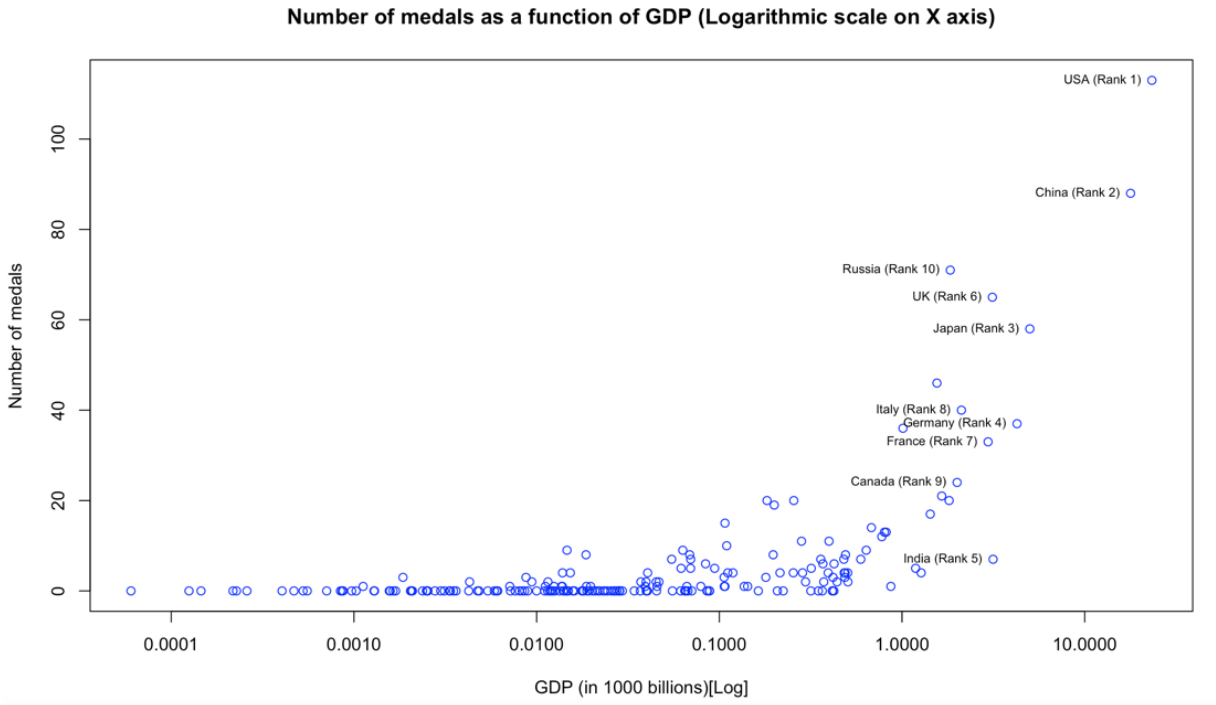
**Conditional density table**

| GDP\ Medals | 0 | 1-9 | ≥10 | Total |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| $< 10^{10}$ | 0.891 | 0.105 | 0.000 | 1 |
| $10^{10} - 10^{11}$ | 0.651 | 0.349 | 0.000 | 1 |
| $10^{11} - 10^{12}$ | 0.176 | 0.608 | 0.216 | 1 |
| $> 10^{12}$ | 0.000 | 0.181 | 0.831 | 1 |

A country with a GDP less than $10^{10}$, can only win a maximum of 9 medals at the Olympic Games and with a chance of winning at least one medal of 10,5% ; when a country's GDP $10^{10}$ and$10^{11}$, it can also not win more than 9 medals at the Olympic Games, but it has a 34,9% chance of winning at least one medals ; a country with a GDP betwee$10^{11}$ and$10^{12}$ a 21,6% chance of winning more than 10 medals at the Olympic Games, a 60,8% chance of winning between 1 and 9 medals and a 17,6% chance of not winning any medals ; when $10^{12}$, it will win at least one medal at the Olympic Games anyway, it will also have an 83,1% chance of winning more than 10 medals.
We can see that the higher is the GDP, the higher is the probability of winning medals.

We can see that the number of medals won per country depends on the country's GDP. By the fact that the relationship of independence of the variables is not respected:
P (PIB = $< 10^{10}$ | Medals = 0) $\neq$ P (PIB = $>10^{12}$ | Medals = 0). The former equals 0,891 and the latter equals 0, which is not the same result, so we can conclude that they are dependent on each other.

## Figure 1.3



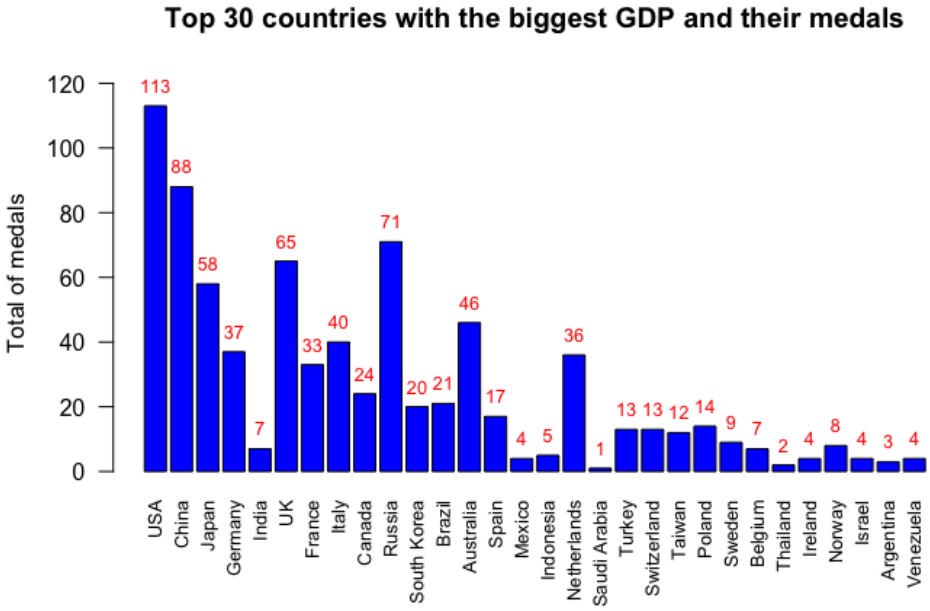

From this scatterplot, we can see that the more GDP increases, the more medals the country will win at the Olympic Games. As we have also stated, some countries do not follow this idea properly, there are exceptions or anomalies. But overall, we can say that the correlation between the two variables is positive.

After calculating the correlation between the two variables with our software R, the correlation is 0,828. This explains that there is a positive correlation, and that the correlation is quite strong, it also explains that if we increase the GDP by $10^6$, the number of medals increases by 0.828 in theory. But in practice, this is not quite the case, sometimes it does not increase the number of medals won by country if its GDP increases. Conversely, the number of medals can increase twice as much when the GDP is increased by $10^6$.

## Figure 1.4

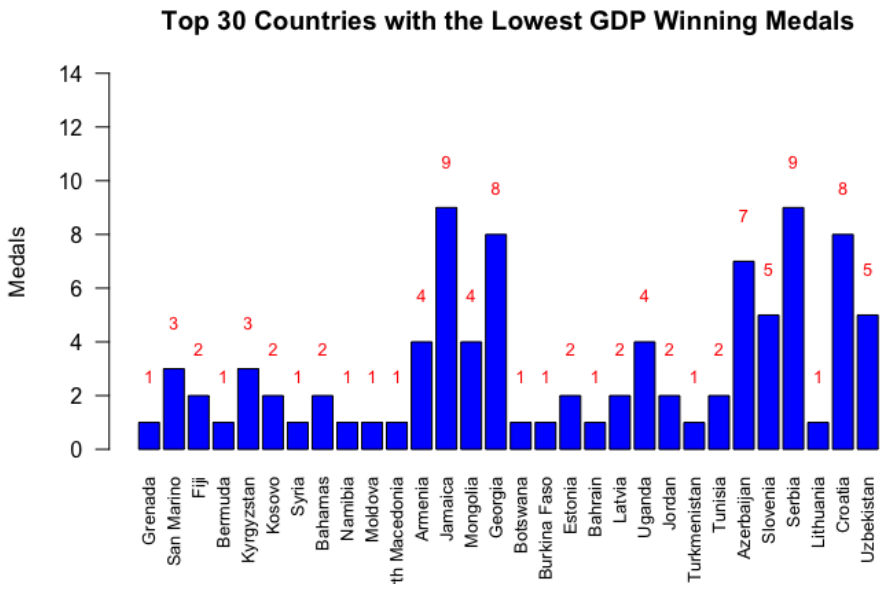
**(the same descriptive analysis as the figure 1.1)**

We will compare the number of medals won by the 30 largest GDPs with the 30 smallest GDPs that won at least one medal. This comparison will allow us to see how countries with low GDP compete in Olympic medal levels with countries with high GDP.




**Descriptive analysis of Figure 1.5**

Figure 1.5

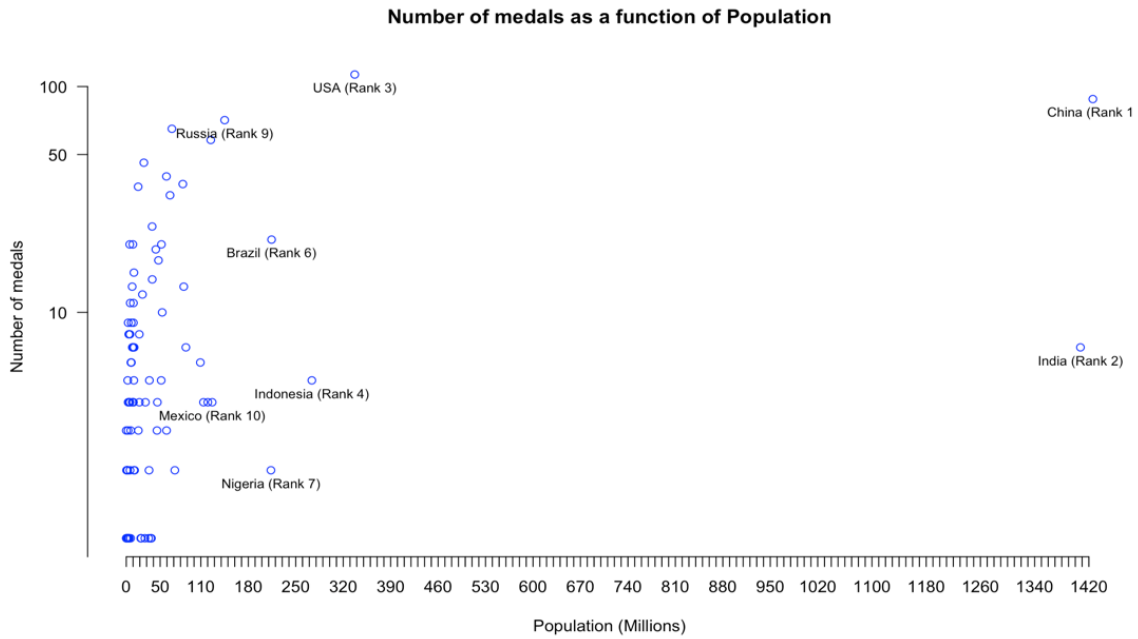



This figure highlights the top 30 countries with the lowest GDPs. On the x-axis, from left to right, we find the countries from the smallest of the 30 GDPs to the largest, from the 30 highest GDPs. For the y-axis, we find the number of medals won. Each blue bar defines a country, and the height of the bar defines the number of medals won. Some countries stand out, such as Armenia, Georgia, Tunisia, Serbia, and Croatia, thanks to several medals won, more than 5 to be precise. Of the 30 countries with the lowest GDP to have won at least one medal, 11 countries have won only one medal. 14 countries are between 2 and 5 medals. And there are only 5 countries left with a few medals ranging from 7 to 9. This makes it possible to divide in 3 groups these 30 countries.

**Pooling of Figures 1.1 and 1.5**

Figure 1.5 shows that the countries with the most medals are between 7 and 9 medals, while in figure 1.4 the countries with 1 to 10 medals are the countries with the least medals. And still the countries with a small GDP that are the most medal-winning countries, at the 2020 Olympics, are only 5. That could imply that they won a sport or discipline of choice in the country. Contrary to the 30 biggest GDPs they have an average of 26 medals won versus only an average of 3 medals won for the 30 smallest GDPs (that have at least won 1 medal). The gap between the two averages can't be overlooked.
But correlation isn't causality. There is a large difference in average medals earned by high and low GDP, but to say that GDP is the main factor wouldn't really be fair. In GDP, several factors are not considered, such as genetics. If we take the case of Georgia, which has won 8 medals at the 2020 Olympics in 3 sports: wrestling, judo and weightlifting. These sports are included in Georgian culture. If we look at the other disciplines that are a bit more international, their performance Isn't as impressive as in wrestling, judo and weightlifting.

## Figure 1.6




This figure compares the number of inhabitants of a country on x-axis with the number of medals won at the Tokyo Olympic Games in 2020 on the y-axis. The y-axis is on a log scale, explaining why the 50 and 100 are this close. As we can see from Figure 1.6, it is not necessarily that the country with the most inhabitants will win the most medals. The figure 1.6 also shows that there is a clear population gap between China, India and the rest of the world. China, which has the largest population in the world, ranks second in the worlds in terms of medals. India, the second most populous country, has not won many medals at the Olympic Games. The country with the most medals is the United States but they have 4 times fewer inhabitants than China, which is the second most medalist country.

As a result, having a large population does not necessarily increase the chances of winning more medals at the Olympic Games. Indonesia and Nigeria are also good examples, they are respectively the 4$^{th}$ and 7$^{th}$ most populous countries in the world, but they are not very productive in terms of medals at the Olympic Games.

The correlation between the number of inhabitants of a country and the number of medals won by that country is 0,437, the correlation between these two variables is positive but weak. This means that the population of a country may increase, but it will not have much impact on the number of Olympic medals won by that country.

The correlation factor between the number of inhabitants per country and the number of Olympic medals per country compared to that between the GDP of a country and the number of Olympic medals per country, the former is low compared to latter, which is high or very high. This may tell us that the population by country variable that is very weak in the performance of the country at the Olympic Games, so that it would not make sense in the result of the country at the Olympic Games. GDP by country is an important variable that could influence the result of the country at the Olympic Games. But correlation is not causality, so it is only hypothesis.

## 7. Limitations

**Difficulties in finding data**
Data taken from the Kaggle site were incomplete. There was a lack of medals won for several countries, including the Cook Islands, Taiwan and Palestine. For these countries, we had troubles finding these data; we had to use The Cook Islands Statistics Office for the Cook Islands, Statista for Taiwan, and World Bank for Palestine. Then we had to add them manually into our R software to be able to make our contingency tables and graphs.

**Other factors not taken into account**
It has been noted that a correlation exists between the GDP of a country and the number of medals won at the Olympic Games per country. However, there are countries that do not follow this correlation. Some countries whose GDP is low or even very low, still win several medals at the Olympic Games.

The number of medals won therefore does not stop at GDP per country, many other factors must be considered. Some sports are in the culture of some countries, they are used to being the favorites in that sport or that discipline, but it has nothing to do with GDP.

Conversely, countries with a large GDP will not necessarily win many medals at the Olympic Games. They will not necessarily focus on the level of their athletes at the Olympic Games but will focus on other areas; a very good example is Saudi Arabia, some of the major Arab Emirates are using their money for football. By investing in football, the notoriety of the country will increase, but also the notoriety of the emirate, which has brought the best players to its country.

## 8. Discussion

The results of our analysis confirm our initial hypothesis, revealing a positive correlation between GDP and the number of medals won. A country's GDP can have some influence on its success in winning medals. Despite that, there are exceptions to this rule. On the contrary, population size has a much weaker influence on the number of medals won.

To simplify the analysis, we have used different types of visualization such as histograms, scatterplots, and bar charts to illustrate the links between GDP, population and the number of medals. To measure these relationships, we calculated correlations.

To expand our analyses scientifically, it would have been relevant to explore the cultural aspects and sports policies of a country, or to consider how often a country participates in the Olympic Games. The popularity of each sport in different countries could also have been another factor. These different variables might have enriched our perspectives.

We were limited by the lack of data for some countries and the difficulty to represent some situations with graphs. Geopolitics could have been studied, because it has a real impact on the number of medals a country can win. There have been boycotts for political or ecological reasons and some countries have been banned from taking part in the Olympic Games during national conflicts, all of that have played an important part in the lack of interest in the Games for certain populations. The lack of popularity of the Olympic Games in different countries is directly linked to the fact that these states are indifferent to winning Olympic medals and do not invest in this event. Financial investment by states could have been another dimension to analyze, but it is hard to find, and websites are not always reliable. Finally, genetic characteristics also play a significant role in athletic performance and are not included in our visualizations.

# 9. Bibliography

Manual addition of the GDP of the Cook Islands: https://stats.gov.ck/
List of countries participating in the Olympic Games in Japan in 2020 and the number of medals per country: https://www.kaggle.com/datasets/berkayalan/2021-olympics-medals-in-tokyo/
https://olympics.com
GDP of Taiwan: fr.statista.com
GDP of Palestine: https://datatopics.worldbank.org/
Reference for analysis:
https://fr.wikipedia.org/wiki/Géorgie_aux_Jeux_olympiques_d%27été_de_2020

References for Appendix-Supplements:
https://www.marianne.net/agora/tribunes-libres/pourquoi-certains-pays-raflent-la-mise-aux-jeux-olympiques-l-economie-politique
https://major-prepa.com/geopolitique/la-geopolitique-des-jeux-olympiques/
https://www.cairn.info/les-jeux-du-monde--9782200631550-page-9.htm

Help for the traduction ( french into English)
https://fr.pons.com/traduction-texte

## A. Supplementary appendix

The nations with the most medals are also the ones with the highest GDPs. The higher a country's GDP, the more resources it must invest in leisure activities. The United States is in first place because of its desire to demonstrate its supremacy, reinforcing the prestige of the country globally. The Olympic Games are also a political competition. The ranking of the most countries with the most medals confirms this, with Russia in second place, after the USA. Russia and USA are the eternal rivals and the fact that they appear side by side in the rankings is the proof of this. They have always used diverse domains such as science or astronomy to surpass others and reinforce their national status, just as they do at the Olympic Games. China who is in the second place in the highest list of GDPs only participated to 23 Olympic Games but has won 636 medals totally. It is necessary for the countries with high GDP to assert themselves in the eyes of the world with those globally watched competitions.

Although the Olympic Games aim to encourage neutrality, we can see that these Olympic competitions have evolved into an occasion dominated by nationalism.

The Olympic Games reflect global geopolitics, involving boycotts and historic bans on participation, which could explain why some countries win fewer medals than others. Despite the Olympic values of equity, it is generally the wealthiest nations that dominate, and it is not as fair as they want us to see it.

## B. Appendix – Code R

```
#Figure 1.1 and 1.4

tableau = read.csv('/Users/paulmicheli/Desktop/Projet Stats/projet_stats.csv')

tableau_filtre = head(tableau[order(tableau$GDP, decreasing = TRUE), ], 30)

ylim_max = max(tableau_filtre$Total) + 10

barplot(tableau_filtre$Total,
        names.arg = tableau_filtre$Country,
        main = "Top 30 countries with the biggest GDP and their medals",
        xlab = " ",
        ylab = "Total of medals",
        col = "blue",
        las = 2,
        cex.names = 0.8,
        ylim = c(0, ylim_max))

text(x = barplot(tableau_filtre$Total, plot = FALSE),
     y = tableau_filtre$Total,
     labels = tableau_filtre$Total,
     pos = 3,
     cex = 0.8,
     col = "red")

##############################################################################
#####
#Figure 1.2
tableau = read.csv('/Users/paulmicheli/Desktop/Projet Stats/projet_stats.csv')

options(scipen = 999)

tableau_filtre = head(tableau[order(tableau$Total, decreasing = TRUE), ], 30)

ylim_max = 30

barplot(tableau_filtre$GDP,
        names.arg = tableau_filtre$Country,
        main = "Top 30 of the countries with the most medals and their GDP",
        xlab = " ",
        ylab = "GDP (in 1000 billions)",
        col = "blue",
        las = 2,
        cex.names = 0.8,
        ylim = c(0, ylim_max))

legend("topright",
       legend = c("number of medals"),
       pch = 20,
```

```
      col = c("red"))

text(x = barplot(tableau_filtre$GDP, plot = FALSE),
    y = tableau_filtre$GDP,
    labels = format(tableau_filtre$Total, scientific = FALSE),
    pos = 3,
    cex = 1,
    col = "red")
##############################################################################
#####
#Figure 1.3

tableau = read.csv('/Users/paulmicheli/Desktop/Projet Stats/projet_stats.csv.csv')

tableau = tableau[order(-tableau$GDP), ]

top10 = tableau[1:10, ]

plot(tableau$GDP, tableau$Total,
    main="Number of medals as a function of GDP (Logarithmic scale on X axis)",
    xlab="GDP (in billions)[Log]",
    ylab="Number of medals",
    pch=21,
    col="blue",
    log="x")

text(top10$GDP, top10$Total,
    labels = paste(top10$Country, " (Rank ", seq_along(top10$Country), ")", sep = ""),
    pos = 2,
    col = "black",
    cex = 0.7)
##############################################################################
#####
#Figure 1.5

tableau = read.csv('/Users/paulmicheli/Desktop/Projet Stats/projet_stats.csv')

options(scipen = 999)

tableau_medailles = tableau[tableau$Total > 0, ]

tableau_filtre = head(tableau_medailles[order(tableau_medailles$GDP), ], 30)

ylim_max = max(tableau_filtre$Total) + 5

bp = barplot(tableau_filtre$Total,
            names.arg = tableau_filtre$Country,
            main = "Top 30 Countries with the Lowest GDP Winning Medals",
            xlab = " ",
            ylab = "Medals",
            col = "blue",
```

```
            las = 2,
            cex.names = 0.8,
            ylim = c(0, ylim_max))

text(x = bp,
     y = tableau_filtre$Total + 1,
     labels = tableau_filtre$Total,
     pos = 3,
     cex = 0.8,
     col = "red")
##############################################################################
#####
#Figure 1.6
tableau = read.csv('/Users/paulmicheli/Desktop/Projet Stats/projet_stats.csv')

tableau = tableau[order(-tableau$Population), ]

top10 = tableau[1:10,]

plot(tableau$Population / 1e6, tableau$Total,
     main="Number of medals as a function of Population",
     xlab="Population (Millions)",
     ylab="Number of medals",
     pch=21,
     col="blue",
     log="y",
     axes=FALSE)

text(top10$Population / 1e6, top10$Total,
     labels = paste(top10$Country, " (Rank ", seq_along(top10$Country), ")", sep = ""),
     pos = 1,
     col = "black",
     cex = 0.8)

axis(1, at = seq(0, max(tableau$Population / 1e6), by = 10),
     labels = seq(0, max(tableau$Population / 1e6), by = 10))

axis(2, las = 1, at = c(0, 10, 50, 100))

##############################################################################
cor(gdp$Total,gdp$GDP)

cor(gdp$Total,gdp$Population)
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# Déclaration d’honneur

Par la présente, j’affirme avoir pris connaissance des documents d’information et de prévention du plagiat émis par l’Université de Neuchâtel et m’être renseigné-e correctement sur les techniques de citation. J’atteste par ailleurs que le travail rendu est le fruit de ma réflexion personnelle et a été rédigé de manière autonome.
Je certifie que toute formulation, idée, recherche, raisonnement, analyse ou autre création empruntée à un tiers est correctement et consciencieusement mentionnée comme telle, de manière claire et transparente, de sorte que la source en soit immédiatement reconnaissable, dans le respect des droits d’auteur et des techniques de citations.
Je suis conscient-e que le fait de ne pas citer une source ou de ne pas la citer clairement, correctement et complètement est constitutif de plagiat. Je prends note que le plagiat est considéré comme une faute grave au sein de l’Université. J’ai pris connaissance des risques de sanctions administratives et disciplinaires encourues en cas de plagiat (pouvant aller jusqu’au renvoi de l’université).
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Au vu de ce qui précède, je déclare sur l’honneur ne pas avoir eu recours au plagiat ou à toute autre forme de fraude.

Neuchâtel, Décembre 2021 Les auteurs.

*Texte basé sur le document « Déclaration sur l'honneur » du Rectorat de l’Université de Neuchâtel.*